Question ID fc3d783a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Advanced Math	Nonlinear equations in one variable and systems of equations in two variables	

ID: fc3d783a

In the xy-plane, a line with equation $2y = 4.5$ intersects a parabola at exactly one point. If the parabola has equation $y = -4x^2 + bx$, where b is a positive constant, what is the value of b?

ID: fc3d783a Answer

Correct Answer:
6

Rationale

The correct answer is 6. It's given that a line with equation $2y = 4.5$ intersects a parabola with equation $y = -4x^2 + bx$, where b is a positive constant, at exactly one point in the *xy*-plane. It follows that the system of equations consisting of $2y = 4.5$ and $y = -4x^2 + bx$ has exactly one solution. Dividing both sides of the equation of the line by 2 yields $y = 2.25$. Substituting 2.25 for y in the equation of the parabola yields $2.25 = -4x^2 + bx$. Adding $4x^2$ and subtracting bx from both sides of this equation yields $4x^2 - bx + 2.25 = 0$. A quadratic equation in the form of $ax^2 + bx + c = 0$, where a, b, and c are constants, has exactly one solution when the discriminant, $b^2 - 4ac$, is equal to zero. Substituting 4 for a and 2.25 for c in the expression $b^2 - 4ac$ and setting this expression equal to 0 yields $b^2 - 4(4)(2.25) = 0$, or $b^2 - 36 = 0$. Adding 36 to each side of this equation yields $b^2 = 36$. Taking the square root of each side of this equation yields $b = \pm 6$. It's given that b is positive, so the value of b is 6.

Question Difficulty:
Hard